
WORK THROUGH THE SAME LAUNCH BEFORE CHOOSING

Product Management or Product Marketing?

Both roles need to understand customers. A product manager uses that understanding to help decide what the product should do. A product marketing manager uses it to define who the product is for, how to explain it, and how to help customers choose and adopt it.

There's overlap. Product marketing can influence product priorities, and product managers may help with pricing, sales conversations, and launches. Ask how the team divides that work.

1 Follow one customer problem

Imagine a company selling scheduling software to clinics. Staff are spending time calling patients who miss appointments.

The product manager could investigate why reminders aren't helping, choose which change to test, and work with engineering and design on that change. The product marketing manager could research how clinics evaluate reminder tools, compare alternatives, and explain the feature to the people buying it.

EXAMPLE

Ask the hiring manager, "When customers raise a problem like this, which part would I own? Who decides the feature priority, and who decides how we position the solution?"

Listen for actual decisions and examples. A phrase such as "customer obsessed" doesn't tell you how the work is divided.

2 Compare the work you would produce

In product management, you might produce research findings, requirements, priorities, and a plan for measuring whether a change helped.

In product marketing, you might produce positioning, a competitor comparison, sales training, launch materials, or a recommendation about which buyers to focus on.

EXAMPLE

For the clinic example, a product requirement might describe when reminders should be sent and what patients can do from the message. A sales brief might explain which clinics need the feature, what the feature does, and its current limitations.

Ask what you'd be expected to produce in the first three months. If you prefer buyer interviews and sales materials to defining product behavior, that answer can help you choose between the openings.

3 Ask how the two roles work together

Product marketing needs accurate information about the product. Product management needs to hear what buyers understand, what they question, and what stops them from choosing it.

That conversation should happen before the announcement. A customer objection may reveal a missing capability, unclear wording, or a difference between the buyer and the person using the product.

EXAMPLE

"Clinics keep asking whether patients can reply to the reminder. The feature only sends messages today. Should we change the product plan, or make that limitation clearer in the sales materials?"

That is a question the two roles can work through together. In the interview, ask for a recent example of customer feedback changing a product or launch decision.

4 Read the compensation figures correctly

The Levels.fyi US snapshot captured on September 5, 2026 showed:

Product Manager: \$168,000 to \$330,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median total compensation: \$230,000. 90th percentile: \$455,000.

Product Marketing Manager: \$163,000 to \$246,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median total compensation: \$202,829. 90th percentile: \$302,000.

These ranges describe the middle half of reported compensation, including stock and bonus. They combine different companies, locations, and experience levels in tech-focused samples. They aren't starting salaries or limits on what you could earn.

EXAMPLE

"What level are you hiring at, and what's the range for this location? Can you separate base salary, stock, and target bonus?"

Compare the answers for the openings themselves. Don't choose a job you wouldn't enjoy because its overall sample has a higher median.

5 Look at the next role, not just the next title

Product managers can progress to senior, group, director, or VP positions. Product marketing managers can progress to senior roles and leadership of product marketing or broader marketing teams.

Those routes vary by company. A more senior role might cover several products, a larger customer group, more complex decisions, or managing people.

EXAMPLE

"What would I own at the next level that I wouldn't own in this role? Could I grow here without becoming a people manager?"

If the answer is mostly managing people, ask what support you'd get with hiring, feedback, and developing a team. Those are responsibilities you would need to learn in either function.

6 Prepare evidence for the role you want

For a product interview, choose an example where you used customer evidence to recommend a product decision. Explain the alternatives, your reasoning, and what happened after the decision.

For product marketing, choose an example where you learned something about buyers and changed how a product was positioned, explained, or introduced. Show the research and the work it led to, not just the finished slides.

EXAMPLE

If you're practicing without a work example, interview potential users of a product you know. Write a proposed requirement and a short positioning brief. Label them as practice work. Explain what you learned and what you would still need to test.

Before applying, answer:

- ☐ Who is the buyer, and who uses the product?
- ☐ Which decisions would I own?
- ☐ What would I produce first?
- ☐ Who owns the other product and marketing responsibilities?
- ☐ What evidence from my experience fits this opening?
- ☐ What would I need to learn?
- ☐ What are the level, pay basis, and progression requirements?

Bring the unanswered questions to the recruiter. You'll be able to discuss the job you want rather than relying on two similar titles.

Salary sources: Levels.fyi US role pages, captured September 5, 2026. Recheck current figures before using them in a negotiation.

<https://www.levels.fyi/t/product-manager?countryId=254>

<https://www.levels.fyi/t/marketing/title/product-marketing-manager?country=254>

Role sources: Atlassian's Product Manager guide and Amazon Jobs 2954949, Sr. Product Marketing Manager, Multi-Channel Fulfillment. The clinic scenario and dialogue are illustrative, not accounts of Dennis's work.